claim to be ruler of all three Scandinavian countries. She intended to keep them together and pass them to Eric as a single block, so she ordered a constitution drafted that would formalize their union. All three kingdoms would be "eternally united" under a single king; each would keep its own laws and customs; each was obligated to fight to defend the other two; and foreign alliances made by one would bind all three.[5]

On June 17, 1397, this constitution was signed by aristocrats from all three countries in a ceremony at Kalmar. Young Eric was crowned king of a unified Scandinavia, but his great-aunt Margaret—forty-five years old, the wife of a king since the age of ten, ruler of two countries for the last decade—was the real sovereign.

FIFTEEN YEARS after the death of the queen's son Olaf, a penniless stranger arrived in the Teutonic state of Prussia, where he took up residence in a small village near Graudenz. The contemporary Prussian historian Johann von Posilge records the event: "Here he was discovered by some merchants who asked him whether he was well-known in Denmark," he writes, "since he looked very much like King Olaf. He said that he was not the king. Then they left him but returned with some other men and addressed him as their lord, the King of Denmark and Norway."[6]

How the merchants knew, fifteen years after the fact, what Olaf looked like is a fair question. Posilge doesn't say, but the rest of the story suggests that the "merchants" may in fact have been native schemers, attempting to mount an upset to Margaret's power. They took the man to the coastal city of Danzig and "showed him great honor," setting up a court for him, giving him everything he wanted, and even making a seal for him. The mysterious stranger, possibly weak-minded, embraced his new identity and agreed to send Margaret a message, reclaiming his crown.[7]

The inevitable discovery took place as soon as he was brought into the queen's presence. "He was shown to be false in every respect," Posilge explains, "since he was neither born in the kingdom nor was able to speak the language" (something the conspirators should possibly have considered ahead of time). Unmasked, he confessed that he was actually a native of northern Hungary and that he had accepted his new identity only because the people of Danzig had heaped him with honors.[8]

Queen Margaret condemned him to death. In the international marketplace in the southern province of Scania, he was burned at the stake, forced to hold all the letters he had sent to the queen in his arms as he died.

THE UNION OF KALMAR had brought the countries together, but the document